



Hypertension (High Blood Pressure)

Keep your heart healthy by learning how to identify and manage high blood pressure.

DC | HEALTH
GOVERNMENT OF THE DISTRICT OF COLUMBIA



What is Hypertension?

Hypertension, or high blood pressure, happens when blood moves through your arteries with too much force. Overtime, this can strain your heart and blood vessels. It usually has no symptoms, which is why it is important to check your blood pressure regularly.



How to Know If I'm At Risk?

- If you have a family history of hypertension (high
- Are experiencing weight related health risks
- Eat high sodium or processed foods like fast food and processed snacks
- Are not getting enough physical activity
- Smoke and drinking alcohol

Learn about your blood pressure numbers and what they mean:

Blood Pressure Category	Systolic mm Hg (upper number)	and/or	Diastolic mm Hg (lower number)
Normal	Less than 120	and	Less than 80
Elevated	120-129	and	Less than 80
High Blood Pressure (Hypertension) Stage 1	130-139	or	80 - 89
High Blood Pressure (Hypertension) Stage 2	140 or Higher	or	90 or higher
Hypertensive Crisis (consult your doctor immediately)	Higher than 180	and/or	Higher than 120

Source: American Heart Association



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How can hypertension be managed and treated?

- **Eat healthy foods:** choose fruits, vegetables, and whole grains.
- **Be Active:** Aim for 30 minutes of movement most days.
- **Limit salt intake:** Cut back on processed and fast foods.
- **Manage stress:** Try deep breathing, walking, or fun exercises to relax.
- **Avoid smoking and drinking:** These behaviors can raise your blood pressure.
- **Take your medication**
- **Check your blood pressure regularly:** Get a blood pressure monitor, visit your primary care doctor, or use in-pharmacy blood pressure monitors.
- **Medication Management**
- **Managing High Blood Pressure:** Taking medication for high blood pressure is a smart move. It helps keep your heart and body healthy.



Resources

For tips and resources to help you build and maintain healthy habits, you can visit:

- » **LivingWell DC:** Visit livingwell.dc.gov/page/go-go-dc for tools to help you eat healthy, exercise, get healthy sleep go to the doctor, and quit smoking.
- » **DC Fire and EMS Department:** Visit any DC fire station for blood pressure monitoring [Blood Pressure Program | fems](#)
- » **LinkUDMV:** Find free and low-cost blood pressure self-monitoring programs on linkudmv.org by searching for “blood pressure”.
- » **Manage High Blood Pressure:** Learn more about your blood pressure numbers and how to manage high blood pressure at heart.org/en/health-topics/high-blood-pressure

